

About Who Eats Whom

“When we try to pick out anything by itself, we find it hitched to everything else in the universe.” – John Muir

Our Mission

Who Eats Whom exists to showcase the deep interconnectedness of life on Earth. Our goal is to build a centralized, searchable repository of species’ feeding relationships—each one linked to a verifiable photograph of the interaction. By bringing these records together in one place, we aim to make it easy for anyone— from scientists to the general public— to learn what species eat, and to explore the web of interactions that together make up the global ecological system.

Why We Built This

For much of the history of ecology, confirmed feeding interactions have been scattered across small natural history notes buried in taxon-specific journals. These records are invaluable, but difficult to discover. Many never make it to the people who could benefit from them—students, naturalists, teachers, land managers, ecologists, and anyone simply curious about the world outside their window.

Who Eats Whom was created to solve this problem. Instead of digging through decades of natural history literature, users can now search, explore, and visualize feeding interactions supported by clear photographic evidence contributed by the global iNaturalist community.

What’s in the Database

All records on Who Eats Whom come from iNaturalist observations that show a feeding interaction. To appear on the site:

1. A user must first join the [Who Eats Whom project](#) on iNaturalist.
2. Users then add separate observations for the “**eater**” and the **organism being eaten**.
3. Users then link the two observations in the “observation fields” section by adding the partner observation’s URL.
4. When both observations reach **Research Grade**, they are automatically sent to the Who Eats Whom database.

We include a wide range of interactions in our definition of feeding—including predation, scavenging, parasitism, and pollination—and future versions of the site will allow users to filter by interaction type.

As of late 2025, the database includes ~**13,000 verified feeding records** from around the world, each tied to a real photograph.

How the Data Are Created

Records come entirely from the iNaturalist community. No computer vision or automated detection is used—every observation is manually added by project members who either photographed the event themselves or noticed that someone else’s upload captured a feeding interaction.

This combination of community participation and manual review helps maintain high data quality and ensures that every record is real, specific, and verifiable.

Tools for Exploring the Web of Life

Who Eats Whom offers multiple ways to explore species interactions:

- **Grid View:** View photos of the feeding interaction, and follow links to the observations on iNaturalist
- **Graph View:** Explore what a species eats, organized by broad groups (mammals, insects, plants, etc.).
- **Network View:** Visualize the network of organisms connected by feeding relationships.
- **Map View:** See how feeding interactions vary across geography.
- **Interactive Global Food Web Tool:** Manipulate and zoom through the global network of feeding relationships, seeing how species are linked across ecosystems and continents.

Our long-term vision is to make Who Eats Whom a one-stop resource for anyone—from casual naturalists to research scientists—interested in discovering, exploring, or analyzing trophic interactions.

How It Started

The seed of Who Eats Whom was planted in the summer of 2014. As an undergraduate field assistant studying snake mimicry in eastern North Carolina, **Bradley Allf** heard a friend (Chris Akcali) describe seeing a Southeastern Five-lined Skink eat a wood cockroach earlier that

season. Curious whether this interaction had ever been formally documented, Chris searched through old issues of *Herpetological Review* and found that it had not—so he decided to publish the observation as a natural history note.

Bradley remembered thinking that there should be a centralized place for these kinds of records—somewhere more accessible than scattered natural history notes, and somewhere that could grow continuously as new interactions were observed.

He carried the idea into graduate school, eventually building a small mockup for an R programming class and later releasing a [rudimentary first version](#). The idea survived, evolved, and expanded.

In 2025, while a postdoc at North Carolina State University, Bradley connected with computer scientist **Aditi Mallavarapu**, who shared enthusiasm for the project and brought expertise in networks, databases, and software development. With her student **Nikhil Vasudeva**, they rebuilt the site and launched the much improved version 2.0 of Who Eats Whom in late 2025.

Our Team



Dr. Bradley Allf – Founder

Postdoctoral researcher in ecology, citizen science, and biodiversity.



Dr. Aditi Mallavarapu – Technical Lead

Computer scientist specializing in networks, data-driven design, and interactive systems.



Nikhil Vasudeva – Developer

Undergraduate researcher contributing to development, data pipelines, and interactive tools.

We are so grateful to the iNaturalist community and staff, whose shared observations and digital infrastructure, respectively, make this project possible (note that Who Eats Whom is not formally affiliated with iNaturalist in any way).
